

» INDIAN PLAYGROUND

Indian Railways dominates proceedings



It was double delight for Indian Railways as it clinched both the men's and women's titles at the 75th Senior National Basketball Championship, which concluded at the Nehru Indoor Stadium in Chennai. In the women's section, Railways defeated Kerala 75-66 to secure its eighth consecutive crown and 41st overall.

Meanwhile, in the men's final, Railways dethroned defending champion Tamil Nadu 77-69, denying the host team a hat-trick of titles.

It was a collective effort from the Railways men, led by Arvinder Singh, who topped the scoring with 18 points. He was well supported by Kanwar Gurbaz Singh Sandhu and skipper Palpreet Singh, as Railways reclaimed the title it last won in 2010.

During the pre-match training routine, Tamil Nadu's shooting appeared off target, almost a sign of things to come. In the opening quarter, as Railways converted its chances, Tamil Nadu missed simple shots and allowed the visitor to race to a 20-7 lead, which it never relinquished.

Railways' defence was equally impressive, denying the likes of A. Anantharaj and Muin Bek Hafeez the space to attempt their three-pointers. For Tamil Nadu, Arvind Kumar Muthukrishnan was the lone bright spot, finishing with 29 points, but the rest of the team failed to step up.

Earlier in the evening, the Railways women were stretched by a spirited Kerala side in a fiercely contested match worthy of a summit clash.

The teams remained neck and neck for most of the contest until late in the final quarter. Trailing 61-47, Kerala scored 10



Triumphant: The Indian Railways men's and women's teams, which won the Senior National basketball championships in Chennai. R. RAGU

unanswered points to cut the deficit to just three midway through the fourth quarter. However, Railways responded strongly, scoring nine points in a row to extend the lead back to 12, which proved decisive in defending its crown.

In the playoff matches, Delhi beat Uttar Pradesh 70-61 to claim the men's bronze, while Tamil Nadu defeated Madhya Pradesh 76-49 to secure third place in the women's section.

S. Dipak Ragav

SPORTOON

